

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- The DfE has told the NEU that the 3.5% teacher pay award will be fully funded after all, via roughly £500m freed up by lower local-government pension contributions — a move the union says averts the strike ballot due to open 3 October.
→ **For your school:** Hold off on any in-year budget reallocation for the pay award until the NEU's national executive decision on 24 September.
- The government announced the first overhaul of England's School Food Standards in over a decade — banning deep-fried food and capping processed meat, cakes and sweet treats — though the new rules don't apply until September 2027.
→ **For your school:** Flag the year-plus lead-in to your catering team or provider now; menu and contract changes take time.
- The two DfE consultations flagged in last issue — on education otherwise than at school (EOTAS) oversight and a new 'local SEND inclusion formula' for upfront mainstream funding — both closed today, 18 September, with no outcome expected before the next issue.
→ **For your school:** If your school or trust hadn't responded, today was the last chance; watch for the government response in the coming weeks.
- New FFT Education Datalab analysis confirms secondary suspension and exclusion rates kept falling through autumn 2025/26, but the disadvantage gap held steady — echoed locally by Stocksbridge High's Ofsted finding that disadvantaged pupils too often leave without basic qualifications.
→ **For your school:** Worth cross-checking your own autumn figures against the disadvantage-gap language before it goes into this year's SEF.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

- 18 Sep 2026** — DfE's EOTAS and 'local SEND inclusion formula' consultations both closed today.
- 18 Sep 2026** — Rotherham Schools Forum meets — agenda includes the exclusion & suspensions annual report and an EHCP update.
- 24 Sep 2026** — NEU national executive meets to decide whether to stand down the planned pay strike ballot.
- 2 Nov 2026** — Extended deadline for completing FSM autumn-census eligibility checks (pushed back from 1 October).

NATIONAL POLICY

- **First overhaul of School Food Standards in over a decade.** From 14 September the DfE set out new statutory food standards for schools: deep-fried food is banned, processed meat and cakes/sweet treats are capped (cheese as a main ingredient no more than twice a week, for example), and schools must serve more fruit, vegetables and fibre. The changes are subject to parliamentary approval and won't take effect until September 2027, with secondary-specific measures phased in by 2028 — giving catering

teams a genuine lead-in. It follows this year's wider expansion of free school meals to all Universal Credit households, so schools serving more free meals will also, in time, be serving different ones. ([GOV.UK](#))

→ **For your school:** *Share the implementation timeline with your catering provider or trust now — 2027 sounds distant but supplier contracts and menu redesign take lead time.*

■ FUNDING

■ **£500m pay-funding breakthrough averts threatened strike.** After weeks of NEU pressure over the 3.5% September pay award, the DfE has told the union the increase will be fully funded after all — via roughly £500m freed up by a 4.9 percentage-point fall in employers' local-government pension contributions, money schools keep rather than have clawed back centrally. The NEU called it 'a fully funded pay increase for all teachers' and its national executive meets on 24 September to decide on the strike ballot due to open 3 October. ([Schools Week](#))

→ **For your school:** *Hold off finalising any in-year budget virement for the pay award until the 24 September decision is confirmed.*

■ **FSM autumn-census deadline pushed back a month.** The DfE has extended the deadline for completing free-school-meals eligibility checks for the autumn census from 1 October to 2 November — a one-off extension to support the wider FSM/Universal Credit expansion rollout flagged in last issue. ([GOV.UK \(DfE Update, 16 September 2026\)](#))

→ **For your school:** *If your eligibility-check backlog was tight, this buys a useful extra month.*

■ INCLUSION & SEND

■ **Twin SEND funding/reform consultations closed today.** The EOTAS consultation covers oversight and quality assurance of education arranged outside school for children with EHC plans; the linked 'local SEND inclusion formula' consultation would let local authorities raise the £6,000 SEND top-up threshold — unchanged since 2013 — via schools forum agreement. Both closed 18 September with no outcome yet; both would apply from April 2027 if taken forward, so expect analysis in the coming weeks rather than a result this issue. ([GOV.UK](#))

→ **For your school:** *Watch for the government response — a raised top-up threshold would directly change what counts as 'high needs' funding for your SEND budget.*

■ BEHAVIOUR, EXCLUSIONS & ATTENDANCE

■ **Suspension rates keep falling, but the gap doesn't.** FFT Education Datalab's latest analysis of 2025/26 attendance data (drawn from around 9,000 subscribing schools) finds the combined suspension-and-exclusion rate fell from 4.1% to 3.8% in autumn term, extending the post-pandemic decline seen in earlier years — though primary years 1-4 saw a small rise. Disadvantaged pupils remain far more likely to be excluded or suspended than their peers, a pattern echoed this week by Stocksbridge High's Ofsted finding (see Sheffield & South Yorkshire, below). Figures are FFT's own analysis, provisional pending the DfE's official autumn release. ([FFT Education Datalab](#))

→ **For your school:** *A useful benchmark if disadvantage-gap language is going into this year's SEF.*

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

■ **A quiet week nationally.** No new chief inspector speech, annual report or framework update landed this week following the September toolkit refresh covered in last issue. The most relevant test of that framework came instead from a batch of local inspections — see Sheffield & South Yorkshire, below.

■ SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

■ **Another quiet week — KCSIE 2026 embedding continues.** No significant new safeguarding announcement landed this week; schools are still in the early weeks of applying KCSIE 2026's information-sharing duty and the removal of the 'supervision exemption' covered in last issue. Worth using the lull to check your DSL has actually completed that policy review rather than just diarised it.

■ SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Nine Sheffield schools and nurseries get new Ofsted reports.** The Star's latest round-up covers reports published over the summer and into the first week of term. Swallownest Primary was praised across the board, with inspectors noting pupils 'arrive happily and settle quickly'; Bankwood Community recovered from 'Inadequate' in 2022 to meeting the expected standard in all areas. Stocksbridge High fared worse — two areas rated 'needs urgent improvement' and four 'needs attention', with inspectors flagging 'unacceptable' attendance and disadvantaged pupils leaving without basic qualifications. ([The Star](#))

→ **For your school:** *Stocksbridge's report is a live local example of this week's disadvantage-gap and attendance data — worth a look if you're benchmarking your own inclusion offer.*

▪ **Rotherham Schools Forum meets today.** Today's agenda covers the 2026/27 Dedicated Schools Grant and schools budget update, early 2027/28 budget planning, the exclusion & suspensions annual report, a reduced-timetables annual report, and an EHCP update — a useful read-across given Sheffield's own high-needs budget pressures. Papers weren't published in time for this issue; expect a summary next week. ([Rotherham MBC](#))

JARGON-BUSTER

This week's twin SEND consultations turn on one acronym.

EOTAS — education otherwise than at school — is provision a local authority arranges for a child with an EHC plan who, for reasons such as ongoing ill health, isn't attending a school placement. This week's consultation looked at how councils oversee and quality-assure it.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations

Source	Type	What we track
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.